THE PATIDAR VOICE

HARDIK PATEL, 28

Working President, Pradesh Congress Committee, Gujarat

Carrying a whole agitation on his young shoulders had long made Hardik Patel a Patidar leader to reckon with. The slew of cases against him only proved that he had begun to matter. Enough for the Congress to recruit him in their project to develop next-gen leaders in states. It's a different matter that Hardik started feeling isolated in the state unit, complaining that "Congress did not utilise his potential". After sulking for almost a year, Hardik seems to have hit a plan. Putting his mass communication skills to use, he has launched two outreach programmes—the Janchetana Mahasammelan in November, aimed at "exposing" the state government's "anti-poor policies". Hardik plans to organise around 300 rallies across Gujarat in 2022, the year when the state goes for an assembly election.

In October, Hardik launched 'Nyay Yatra', to ensure justice for families of Covid-19 victims. Close to two lakh people, he claims, died because of the government's poor handling of the pandemic. He plans to meet each family that has lost at least one member to the virus. He has contacted 31,000 families so far in 16,000 villages.

Representing the 12.5 million-strong Patidar community, which makes up 18 per cent of the state's 60 million people, Patel laid claim to the post of state Congress president. But with Congress entrusting Jagdish Thakor, an OBC, with that responsibility and appointing Sukhram Rathwa, a tribal, as leader of opposition, Hardik is expected to concentrate on his core support base, the Patidars, of whom he claims to be the lone, strong voice. He is also likely to contest the assembly election from Ahmedabad. Till then, he wants to negate the advantage BJP has gained after installing Bhupendra Patel, a Patidar, as chief minister. He has begun by dismissing Chief Minister Patel as Delhi's puppet and projecting himself as the sole Patidar warrior. ■

– Kiran D. Tare

A WARRIOR IMAGE An ardent devotee of Lord Rama, Hardik likes to pose for photographs carrying a sword, a rifle or a pistol